



Brazil

THE VIBRANT CULTURE OF BRAZIL—with its fusion of music and dance—reflects the rich mix of its ethnic groups. The country also boasts immense natural resources with well-developed mining and manufacturing industries. Brazil grows all its own food and exports large quantities of coffee, sugar cane, soya beans, oranges, and cotton. However, the wealth is not evenly distributed, with some people living in luxury while most struggle with poverty. São Paulo is home to more than 21 million people, but poverty and lack of housing means that many live in shantytowns without running water or sanitation. Brazil was colonized in the 16th century by the Portuguese, who established their language and their Roman Catholic faith. It remains a deeply Catholic country with a strong emphasis on family life.



AMAZON RAINFOREST
Covering more than one-third of Brazil, the rainforest is home to a huge variety of animals and plant life. At one time, more than 5 million native Indians also lived here, but now only about 200,000 remain. Over the years, vast areas of forest have been cut down to provide timber for export, to make way for farmland, or to mine minerals such as gold, silver, and iron. The Kaxinawa Indians (left) still cultivate root vegetables as a food crop.



Brazilian morpho butterfly with brilliant blue wings lives in rainforests from Brazil to Venezuela.



BRASÍLIA

Brasília replaced Rio de Janeiro as Brazil's capital in 1960 as part of a scheme to develop the interior of the country. Situated on land that was once rainforest, the city is laid out in the shape of an airplane. Government buildings are in the "cockpit," and residential areas are in the "wings."

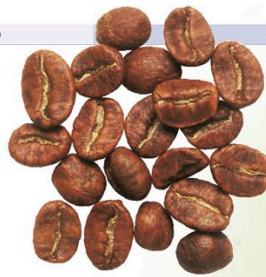
SOCCER ENTHUSIASTS

Brazilians are passionate about soccer, which is played everywhere from beaches to shantytowns. There is fervent support for the national team, which has won the World Cup more times than any other country, most recently in 2002.



PEOPLE OF BRAZIL

Brazilians come from a variety of different ethnic groups, including descendants of the original native Indians, the Portuguese colonizers, African slaves brought over to work in the sugar plantations, and European migrants.



COFFEE

Brazil produces about one-quarter of the world's coffee, which is grown on large plantations in the states of Paraná and São Paulo. However, because world coffee prices go up and down so much, Brazilians are now growing other crops for export as well.

